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Industry Connect

Laptop conversations with Acer

We talk to Jerry Kao, President, Notebook Business Group, Acer, who oversees the product development and brand management of the commercial and consumer notebook business units for the Taiwanese company, and get his perspectives on what's next for Acer and the industry. Exclusive excerpts.



Jerry Kao, President, Notebook Business Group, Acer ▶

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Q Acer's trying to move away from a budget player in the notebook market by offering more premium products. What more should we expect from Acer in the next 18 months?

Jerry Kao: Exactly! As you mentioned that in the past 6 to 12 months I have been trying to transfer my team to get rid of the entry platform trying to move to a more higher entry platform. So how to make my products more attractive? Not just in terms of cost but in terms of feature set is what I am going to do. In terms of notebooks, out of the top five or six notebook OEMs Acer is the only one where we are traditionally focussed on the so called budget or entry segments. But it also means that Acer is the only one which will have a chance to grow from budget to somewhere else. For those companies who are also suffering from too much budget, Acer is a power engine for them to go higher. For example, when talking about GPU company like NVIDIA, Acer is the only one that has the chance to increase GPU numbers because for example ASUS or Lenovo they all already have plenty GPUs. They don't have room to grow but Acer has good room to grow.

Q With respect to Predator series, how will you convince users to consider Acer notebooks as a serious gaming brand?

Jerry Kao: As a gaming brand we need to spread awareness because people don't understand – not at least – everything about gaming. So raising awareness of Acer I think again as a compelling product, we can get some business in gaming. When we talk about compelling in gaming, we need to find our uniqueness. Insight from the gamers is important, because copying is very easy, but some gamers don't know what they want. But when we perceive, when we observe we learn that they need something they don't know and we dive into details to understand why that is and then we bring it to our product. We are going to have more Predator notebooks with some features which some gamers don't know they want yet, but when you show it to them, they just go 'wow'. I think you will see that very soon. But, that does not mean Acer does not copy because I will have whatever my competitor will and on top of that I will have one or two unique gaming features. This is what I am basing my Predator strategy on.

Q When it comes to OEMs, 95% of their SKUs are Intel based. Why don't we see enough AMD SKUs in the market?

Jerry Kao: Let me put it this way, when I am thinking of offering a product, the vendors interaction is the last thing on my mind. I still think about what my customer needs, whether the features

are tempting to customers. So it is true that in the industry in the last one or two years we saw less and less AMD SKUs. If you are thinking about why, I need to say that in terms of competitiveness AMD SKUs are not as competitive as Intel. By competitive I am not just talking about cost, I am also talking about the power consumption, the future upgradeability or the system design and what not. All over I can see that the industry is somehow migrating to Intel, at least that's the trend. But at the same time I am working with AMD on different form factors or different form factor GPU, where Intel doesn't have the upper hand.

Q When is the laptop market going to make the shift to SSDs wholeheartedly?

Jerry Kao: Yeah! If I am talking about accurate timing I don't know. There may not be a 100% transfer because the hard disk still has the capacity matrix for some customers. For those who capacity still matters for, they will always go for hard disks. I don't think that market will die. SSD will become more and more prevalent, but HDDs capturing more than 50% market share is still a challenge because capacity still matters. Maybe in 5 or 10 years, when everybody has their data in the cloud, but that will take time. Plus, this is an industry where people are afraid to put private data onto the cloud. **Q**